

Software Product Management English Jargon Quick Reference

Field-specific terms, contrast pairs, and high-pressure sentence frames

Audience: software product managers, product owners, UX leads, engineering managers, growth product teams, platform PMs, and product-operations staff

Focus: A software product-management English curriculum for discovery, roadmaps, user stories, prioritization, metrics, launches, stakeholder negotiation, experimentation, and product strategy.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who already use professional English and need industry-specific terminology, realistic meetings, role-play pressure, careful pushback, and polished workplace outputs.

Teaching stance: this is language and workplace-communication training, not legal, medical, financial, safety, or regulatory advice. Instructors should connect every scenario to the learner's current company policies, local rules, and approved procedures.

Nomenclature and Jargon

These are classroom working definitions. Learners should adapt wording to their organization's policies, systems, and local regulatory environment.

Product Discovery and Problem Framing

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
user need	In software product management, user need is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to separate customer requests from underlying problems.	clarify user need; document user need	Contrast: user need should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify user need and the evidence that supports it.
persona	In software product management, persona is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to separate customer requests from underlying problems.	clarify persona; document persona	Contrast: persona should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify persona and the evidence that supports it.
use case	In software product management, use case is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to separate customer requests from underlying problems.	clarify use case; document use case	Contrast: use case should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify use case and the evidence that supports it.
opportunity cost	In software product management, opportunity cost is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to separate customer requests from underlying problems.	clarify opportunity cost; document opportunity cost	Contrast: opportunity cost should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify opportunity cost and the evidence that supports it.

Roadmaps and Prioritization

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
roadmap	In software product management, roadmap is a structured course of action that assigns priorities, sequencing, assumptions, and responsible roles. Use it when teams need to explain roadmap tradeoffs under executive pressure.	align on the roadmap; revise the roadmap	Contrast: roadmap sets an intended course of action; it is not proof that the work is feasible or approved. Example: Before we revise the roadmap, we need to test the dependency and resource assumptions.
prioritization	Deliberate ordering of work based on value, urgency, risk, capacity, and dependencies.	clarify prioritization; document prioritization	Contrast: prioritization should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify prioritization and the evidence that supports it.
dependency	Work, approval, input, vendor, system, or decision that another activity relies on.	clarify dependency; document dependency	Contrast: dependency should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify dependency and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
capacity	Available people, assets, time, space, or system throughput for a given workload.	clarify capacity; document capacity	Contrast: capacity should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify capacity and the evidence that supports it.

User Stories and Acceptance Criteria

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
user story	In software product management, user story is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to turn vague ideas into buildable requirements.	clarify user story; document user story	Contrast: user story should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify user story and the evidence that supports it.
acceptance criteria	In software product management, acceptance criteria is an approved rule or decision framework that sets what is permitted, required, or acceptable. Use it when teams need to turn vague ideas into buildable requirements.	apply the acceptance criteria; comply with the acceptance criteria	Contrast: acceptance criteria is an approved rule or threshold, not an informal preference. Example: Please confirm which acceptance criteria applies before we commit the team.
edge case	In software product management, edge case is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to turn vague ideas into buildable requirements.	clarify edge case; document edge case	Contrast: edge case should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify edge case and the evidence that supports it.
definition of done	In software product management, definition of done is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to turn vague ideas into buildable requirements.	clarify definition of done; document definition of done	Contrast: definition of done should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify definition of done and the evidence that supports it.

Metrics, Funnels, and Product Analytics

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
activation	In software product management, activation is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss metrics without confusing movement with causation.	clarify activation; document activation	Contrast: activation should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify activation and the evidence that supports it.
retention	In software product management, retention is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss metrics without confusing movement with causation.	clarify retention; document retention	Contrast: retention should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify retention and the evidence that supports it.
funnel	In software product management, funnel is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss metrics without confusing movement with causation.	clarify funnel; document funnel	Contrast: funnel should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify funnel and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
cohort	In software product management, cohort is a defined information asset or analytical construct used to measure, explain, or predict an outcome. Use it when teams need to discuss metrics without confusing movement with causation.	clarify cohort; document cohort	Contrast: cohort should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify cohort and the evidence that supports it.

Experimentation and A/B Testing

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
A/B test	Controlled comparison of two variants to estimate the effect of a change on a defined outcome.	clarify A/B test; document A/B test	Contrast: A/B test should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify A/B test and the evidence that supports it.
hypothesis	In software product management, hypothesis is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to frame experiments with hypotheses and guardrails.	clarify hypothesis; document hypothesis	Contrast: hypothesis should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify hypothesis and the evidence that supports it.
guardrail metric	In software product management, guardrail metric is a defined information asset or analytical construct used to measure, explain, or predict an outcome. Use it when teams need to frame experiments with hypotheses and guardrails.	clarify guardrail metric; document guardrail metric	Contrast: guardrail metric should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify guardrail metric and the evidence that supports it.
statistical significance	In software product management, statistical significance is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to frame experiments with hypotheses and guardrails.	clarify statistical significance; document statistical significance	Contrast: statistical significance should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify statistical significance and the evidence that supports it.

Release Readiness and Go-to-Market

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
release	In software product management, release is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to coordinate launch dependencies across product, engineering, sales, and support.	clarify release; document release	Contrast: release should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify release and the evidence that supports it.
rollback	In software product management, rollback is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to coordinate launch dependencies across product, engineering, sales, and support.	clarify rollback; document rollback	Contrast: rollback should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify rollback and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
enablement	In software product management, enablement is a capability or authorization process used to prepare, verify, or document that a person can perform a role. Use it when teams need to coordinate launch dependencies across product, engineering, sales, and support.	clarify enablement; document enablement	Contrast: enablement should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify enablement and the evidence that supports it.
migration	In software product management, migration is a measurable indicator used to quantify performance, exposure, capacity, quality, or change over time. Use it when teams need to coordinate launch dependencies across product, engineering, sales, and support.	track migration; explain a change in migration	Contrast: migration measures a result or condition; it does not, by itself, prove the cause. Example: Before we act, let us track migration by segment and explain what changed.

Platform, APIs, and Technical Debt

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
technical debt	In software product management, technical debt is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss invisible work in business terms.	clarify technical debt; document technical debt	Contrast: technical debt should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify technical debt and the evidence that supports it.
API	Application programming interface; a defined way for software systems to exchange data or trigger actions.	clarify API; document API	Contrast: API should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify API and the evidence that supports it.
platform	In software product management, platform is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss invisible work in business terms.	clarify platform; document platform	Contrast: platform should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify platform and the evidence that supports it.
reliability	In software product management, reliability is a performance or governance dimension that must be protected through defined evidence, thresholds, and accountability. Use it when teams need to discuss invisible work in business terms.	clarify reliability; document reliability	Contrast: reliability should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify reliability and the evidence that supports it.

Stakeholder Pushback and Executive Narrative

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
stakeholder	Person or group with an interest, risk, authority, or dependency in the work.	clarify stakeholder; document stakeholder	Contrast: stakeholder should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify stakeholder and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
strategic fit	In software product management, strategic fit is a measurable indicator used to quantify performance, exposure, capacity, quality, or change over time. Use it when teams need to say no or not now while preserving trust.	track strategic fit; explain a change in strategic fit	Contrast: strategic fit measures a result or condition; it does not, by itself, prove the cause. Example: Before we act, let us track strategic fit by segment and explain what changed.
tradeoff	In software product management, tradeoff is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to say no or not now while preserving trust.	clarify tradeoff; document tradeoff	Contrast: tradeoff should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify tradeoff and the evidence that supports it.
decision memo	In software product management, decision memo is a workplace communication artifact that records facts, interpretation, and the decision or action requested. Use it when teams need to say no or not now while preserving trust.	prepare a decision memo; circulate the decision memo	Contrast: decision memo is a reviewable communication artifact, not an undocumented verbal assurance. Example: The decision memo should state the evidence, caveat, decision owner, and next action.

Industry-Specific Meeting Moves

Situation	Useful language
Product Discovery and Problem Framing	Before we commit, I want to confirm user need, persona, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If user need, segment fit, evidence, opportunity cost, and strategy need review., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Roadmaps and Prioritization	Before we commit, I want to confirm roadmap, prioritization, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If capacity, dependencies, risk, strategic fit, and sequencing must be clear., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
User Stories and Acceptance Criteria	Before we commit, I want to confirm user story, acceptance criteria, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If acceptance criteria, edge cases, analytics, and ux intent need definition., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Metrics, Funnels, and Product Analytics	Before we commit, I want to confirm activation, retention, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If cohorts, instrumentation, seasonality, and counter-metrics need review., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Experimentation and A/B Testing	Before we commit, I want to confirm A/B test, hypothesis, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If sample size, significance, novelty effect, and guardrail metrics matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Release Readiness and Go-to-Market	Before we commit, I want to confirm release, rollback, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If documentation, enablement, migration, monitoring, and rollback need readiness., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Platform, APIs, and Technical Debt	Before we commit, I want to confirm technical debt, API, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If reliability, developer velocity, support burden, and future roadmap risk need translation., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Stakeholder Pushback and Executive Narrative	Before we commit, I want to confirm stakeholder, strategic fit, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If strategic fit, customer segment, cost, and alternatives need a clear recommendation., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.

High-pressure pushback frames

- I understand the urgency. The risk is that we move faster than the evidence or process supports.
- I am not blocking the goal. I am naming the condition we need before the decision is safe and credible.

- If we accept this risk, we should name the owner, document the assumption, and define the trigger for escalation.
- That may be possible, but not under the current scope, timeline, or approval path.
- Let's separate what we know, what we assume, and what still needs confirmation.

Contrast Pairs

Do not confuse	Useful distinction
user need vs opportunity cost	In product discovery and problem framing, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
roadmap vs capacity	In roadmaps and prioritization, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
user story vs definition of done	In user stories and acceptance criteria, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
activation vs cohort	In metrics, funnels, and product analytics, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
A/B test vs statistical significance	In experimentation and a/b testing, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
release vs migration	In release readiness and go-to-market, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
technical debt vs reliability	In platform, apis, and technical debt, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
stakeholder vs decision memo	In stakeholder pushback and executive narrative, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.